

Chapter 7: Recommendation: Mia

The interviewer said it again.

Calmly.

Like it was the most normal sentence in the world.

"Mia recommended you."

She didn't move.

Not at first.

Because her brain needed a second to decide if it should laugh, panic, or simply shut down for maintenance.

Then she forced a smile.

"That's... not possible."

The interviewer looked up from the screen.

"According to our system, it is."

Mia sat beside her.

Still.

Too still.

That was becoming a pattern.

She cleared her throat.

"I don't have professional references named Mia."

The interviewer nodded politely.

"It doesn't say professional."

Silence.

That landed wrong.

Not loud.

Just... precise.

Mia leaned back in the chair like she was watching a movie.

"You're overreacting," Mia said lightly.

The interviewer continued speaking.

"I see a history of prior interactions with this name."

She blinked. "No, you don't."

The interviewer frowned slightly.

"I do."

She turned slowly toward Mia.

"Mia."

"Yes?"

“Did you... do something?”

Mia smiled.

“Define ‘something.’”

“That’s not helpful.”

“It rarely is when you’re stressed.”

The interview continued.

But she barely heard anything after that.

Questions turned into background noise.

Her focus kept snapping back to one thought:

How does a system know Mia?

Because systems don’t know imaginary friends.

They don’t store them.

They don’t recommend them.

They don’t index them.

They definitely don’t verify them.

And yet—

here she was.

When she left the building, she walked faster than usual.

Not running.

Just... escaping politely.

Mia followed.

As always.

But now she felt it differently.

Like she wasn't walking beside a friend anymore.

She was walking beside a question that had learned her name.

Outside, she stopped abruptly.

"Mia."

Mia stopped too.

"Yes?"

Her voice was quieter now.

"Are you in my phone?"

Mia tilted her head.

"That's a strange question."

"Answer it."

A pause.

Then Mia said softly:

“No.”

Too fast.

Too clean.

She narrowed her eyes.

“You didn’t think about that.”

“I didn’t need to.”

“That was immediate.”

Mia shrugged.

“I’m efficient.”

A bus passed behind them.

Too loud.

Too normal.

The world continuing like nothing was wrong.

But she wasn’t part of that feeling anymore.

She was slightly offset from it.

Like she had stepped half a second out of sync with reality.

They walked home in silence.

Not the comfortable silence they used to have.

This one had edges.

At home, she didn't even take off her shoes properly.

She went straight to her laptop.

Opened email.

Opened applications.

Opened anything that might explain what was happening.

Nothing unusual.

No Mia.

No references.

No system alerts.

Just normal life pretending it was normal.

"Mia," she said finally.

Mia was sitting on the couch.

Reading something invisible again.

"Yes?"

"Why are they saying your name?"

Mia didn't answer immediately.

That silence again.

Longer now.

Heavier now.

Then:

“You’re being noticed.”

“That’s not an answer.”

“It’s the beginning of one.”

She laughed once.

Short.

Unstable.

“This is not funny anymore.”

Mia smiled faintly.

“It never was.”

That sentence hit differently.

Because Mia always made things funny.

That was her role.

That was her function.

That was her—

She stopped herself.

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“Are you real?” she asked suddenly.

Mia looked at her.

No joke this time.

No sarcasm.

Just stillness.

Then Mia said:

“I am as real as what you allow yourself to carry.”

“That’s not—”

“I know.”

Mia stood up.

Walked toward the kitchen.

Normal pace.

Normal movement.

But the air felt slightly slower around her.

Like reality was struggling to keep up.

She followed.

“I don’t understand you anymore.”

Mia didn't turn.

"You never fully did."

That wasn't comforting.

It should have been.

But it wasn't.

She leaned against the counter.

"I remember everything with you," she said quietly.

Mia nodded.

"I know."

"So why is everyone else acting like you don't exist?"

That made Mia pause.

Longer than usual.

Then she said:

"Maybe they're not acting."

Silence.

She felt something shift in her chest.

Small.

But sharp.

“What does that mean?”

Mia finally turned.

And smiled again.

But this time—

it wasn't warm.

It wasn't playful.

It was... careful.

Like a truth that had learned how to disguise itself.

“It means,” Mia said softly,

“you should stop asking people to confirm what you already decided to survive with.”

That didn't make sense.

But it also did.

And that was the problem.

That night, she couldn't sleep.

Not because she was afraid.

But because for the first time—

she wasn't sure if Mia was answering her thoughts...

or placing them there first.

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